was the norm. This has taken a heavy toll on the formal and informal sectors associated with the wedding industry.

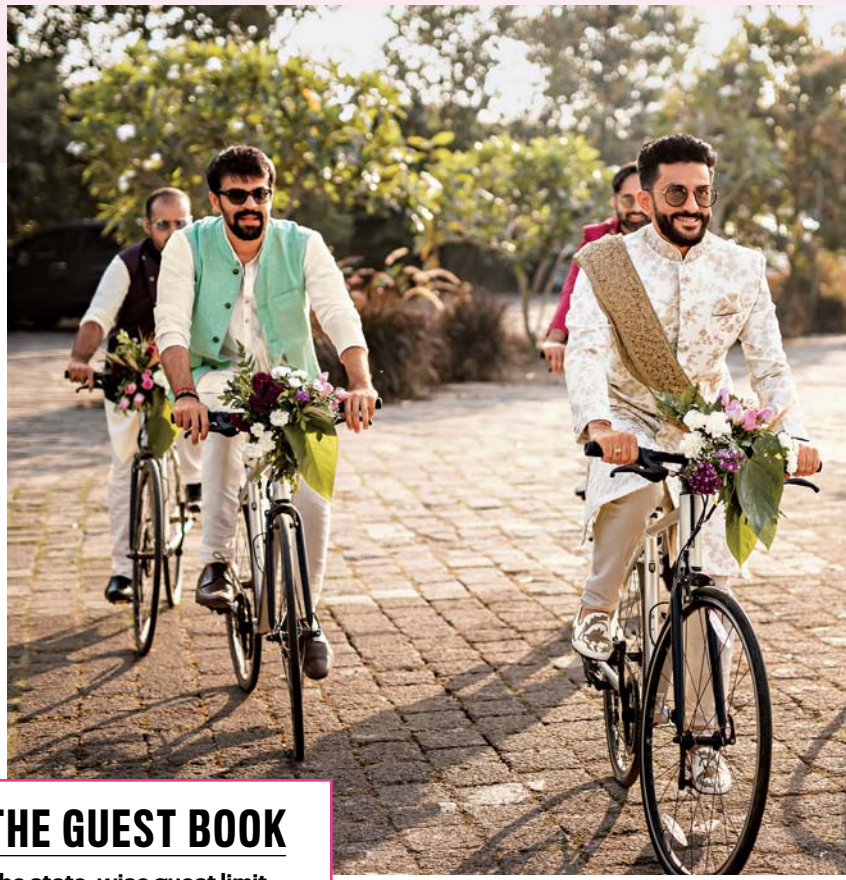
INDUSTRY BLUES

According to Namit Agnihotri, area general manager, The Roseate Hotels & Resorts, "The Covid norms change almost weekly. In January 2022, for instance, we have had almost 60-70 per cent cancellations and about 30-40 per cent postponements." The Indian wedding market, the second-largest after the US, was impacted severely during the second Covid wave in 2021 when the business was shut down completely. "The size and scale of the wedding industry has been affected to the tune of 60-70 per cent and since a large part of the wedding business is informal, you can understand the impact down the chain. High-end hotels, caterers and florists would be able to quantify the loss in numbers, but what about the small decorator, electrician, cook caterer and the *kirana* shops?" asks Nilanjan Ghosh, director, Observer Research Foundation, a think-tank in Delhi.

Rajat Ray, a Kolkata-based wedding photographer, used to book 12 to 20 gigs a year, charging 45,000 for each event. In 2021, though, Ray managed to book just six events and had to slash his fee to Rs 25,000. Bhaskar Karmakar, in the profession since 1998, says things have never been this bad before. The photographer, also from Kolkata, had invested heavily in cameras, lights and other accessories for wedding videography shortly before the pandemic. When the pandemic struck, he was forced to do odd jobs to pay the EMI on the loan he had taken to buy the equipment. "I have joined Zomato and am delivering food and grocery orders to be able to earn," he says.

Prateek Kashyap, founder director of Made in Heaven, a Gurugram-based wedding planning company, says that wedding photography budgets have been cut due to reduction in the number of wedding events. Plus, ceremonies have now changed to, what are known as, "minimonies"—smaller, more intimate events. A few of Kashyap's clients have even asked for the wedding pictures to be delivered electronically only.

Minimonies also mean that business for bandwalas and caterers has dried up too. With smaller gatherings the new norm, there is no *baraat* procession. "We used to have 20 to 25 musicians playing in a programme, but now only eight to 10 are allowed. Out of 70 people in my orchestra, I have kept 30 and the rest are on their own, getting by on some token financial assistance," says Mohammad Zahid of Sohrab Band, Kolkata. Caterers too have seen a reduction in their earnings. Ratan Barua of J.N. Barua Confectionery, Kolkata, has seen a 50 per cent dip in demand and, consequently, earnings, while Ranjan Neogi of Continental Catering Services, a Kolkata-based chain, says he has lost at least 70 per cent of his earnings due to the pandemic.



Photographer: SNAPPED STUDIO
Courtesy: WedMeGood

THE GUEST BOOK

The state-wise guest limit for weddings and the change in policy after the easing of restrictions in Jan-Feb

DELHI
THEN: Up to 20 guests for a gathering at home or at court
NOW: Up to 200 guests

MADHYA PRADESH
THEN: Up to 250 guests
NOW: No cap

MAHARASHTRA
THEN: Up to 50 guests
NOW: 25 per cent of the capacity of the open ground/ banquet halls; maximum 200

TAMIL NADU
Up to 100 guests

UTTAR PRADESH
Up to 100 guests in open spaces

KARNATAKA
200 guests allowed in open spaces; 100 in closed spaces

RAJASTHAN
THEN: Up to 100 guests
NOW: 250 guests (excluding the wedding band)

WEDDINGS REIMAGINED

The millennial's idea of a wedding is informed by tradition, but is far from traditional. It's more practical and tech-enabled. They are more conscious about reducing their carbon footprint and making a positive impact. There have been several